particularly interested in changes, especially if it meant uncertainty about their jobs or the availability of affordable housing. For the system was not totally bad. There was work for all, a free health service and affordable social housing. In 1960, the GDP of Yugoslavia was 2,437 dollars per capita. In Austria it was 6,519, in Italy 9,719, in Germany 10,839 dollars. It was 3,072 in Spain, 2,956 in Portugal, 3,146 in Greece and 4,282 dollars in Ireland. Yugoslav average GDP was, however, lower than that in Bulgaria (2,912), Hungary (3,649), Poland (3,215) and, of course, Czechoslovakia (5,108 dollars), and only higher than that in Romania.

Twenty years later, the average Yugoslav GDP was 6,063 dollars, Slovenian GDP around twice the figure. (For comparison: Irish GDP then was 8,541 dollars, while the Czechoslovakian average was only a little bit less – 7,982 dollars.) This means that, in the post-war period, Eastern Europe was seriously lagging behind the core of Western Europe, though the Czechs and Slovenians were at about the income levels of Spain, Portugal, Greece and Ireland.[81]

However, the difference between Eastern and Western Europe became significant after the 1980s. For 1990, the estimate for GDP for the Czech Republic alone stood at 8,895 dollars and for Slovenia 11,404. At the time it left Yugoslavia, Slovenia was richer than Greece (9,988) and Portugal (10,826) and it was almost at the level of Ireland (11,818 dollars), all measured in Maddison's 1990 international dollars. Eleven years later, in 2001, Slovenia's GDP (in the same units) was 13,843 dollars and the Irish GDP was 23,201 – such was the dramatic success of the Celtic Tiger in the EU and, on the other hand, the cost of transformation in Slovenia!

For Yugoslavs there was also free foreign travel: from about the 1970s, we had this unique possibility of travelling freely abroad, as much as we wanted, with the exception of openly vocal opponents who were denied a passport. When Yugoslavia opened its borders with what was then Western Europe, Slovenia, bordering Italy and Austria, profited the most. Slovenians were the lucky ones in the Communist world. Shopping in Italy or Austria was a fortnightly occurrence. We looked for the products that were not easy to find in the then Yugoslavia or were cheaper abroad, such as Sicilian oranges, bathroom tiles, electronics or fashionable clothes, jeans above all, usually at the lower side of the price scale and in the limited quantities allowed by the Yugoslav Customs. But it did not end with shopping. Books